Before you begin

Alcohol: my story and my diary

Two parts to work on before your cohort begins: your story, and a daily diary. Print these pages, or copy the questions into a notebook that you keep for the whole programme. Write as much or as little as you like. Nothing needs to be shared.

Part 1: My story

1. When did you have your first drink? How old were you, and what was happening in your life at the time?

2. Why did you start drinking? Who was around you, and what did alcohol give you then?

3. How has your drinking changed over the years? Think of times you drank more, less, or stopped for a while.

4. What have you tried before to stop or cut down, and what did you learn from it?

5. What does alcohol give you now? And what does it cost you: your health, sleep, money, relationships, how you feel about yourself?

6. What has brought you to this group, now?

7. Who are you becoming? Describe yourself living alcohol-free.

Part 2: My diary

Keep this diary every day until the cohort begins, and keep going as you go through the programme. You don't need to change anything yet: just notice. Write one line for each drink.

Day 1 Date: _____

Time	Drink and amount	Where	Alone, or with whom?	How I felt just before	Easy or hard to skip?

8. How many drinks did I have today?

9. Which ones could I cut out completely? Which feel very hard to let go of, and why?

10. Did I drink more alone or with others? Socially, after work, with food, at weekends, when stressed or tired?

11. What emotions sat underneath my drinking today? How did I feel while drinking, and afterwards?

Day 2 Date: _____

Time	Drink and amount	Where	Alone, or with whom?	How I felt just before	Easy or hard to skip?

12. How many drinks did I have today?

13. Which ones could I cut out completely? Which feel very hard to let go of, and why?

14. Did I drink more alone or with others? Socially, after work, with food, at weekends, when stressed or tired?

15. What emotions sat underneath my drinking today? How did I feel while drinking, and afterwards?

Day 3 Date: _____

Time	Drink and amount	Where	Alone, or with whom?	How I felt just before	Easy or hard to skip?

16. How many drinks did I have today?

17. Which ones could I cut out completely? Which feel very hard to let go of, and why?

18. Did I drink more alone or with others? Socially, after work, with food, at weekends, when stressed or tired?

19. What emotions sat underneath my drinking today? How did I feel while drinking, and afterwards?

Day 4 Date: _____

Time	Drink and amount	Where	Alone, or with whom?	How I felt just before	Easy or hard to skip?

20. How many drinks did I have today?

21. Which ones could I cut out completely? Which feel very hard to let go of, and why?

22. Did I drink more alone or with others? Socially, after work, with food, at weekends, when stressed or tired?

23. What emotions sat underneath my drinking today? How did I feel while drinking, and afterwards?

Day 5 Date: _____

Time	Drink and amount	Where	Alone, or with whom?	How I felt just before	Easy or hard to skip?

24. How many drinks did I have today?

25. Which ones could I cut out completely? Which feel very hard to let go of, and why?

26. Did I drink more alone or with others? Socially, after work, with food, at weekends, when stressed or tired?

27. What emotions sat underneath my drinking today? How did I feel while drinking, and afterwards?

Day 6 Date: _____

Time	Drink and amount	Where	Alone, or with whom?	How I felt just before	Easy or hard to skip?

28. How many drinks did I have today?

29. Which ones could I cut out completely? Which feel very hard to let go of, and why?

30. Did I drink more alone or with others? Socially, after work, with food, at weekends, when stressed or tired?

31. What emotions sat underneath my drinking today? How did I feel while drinking, and afterwards?

Day 7 Date: _____

Time	Drink and amount	Where	Alone, or with whom?	How I felt just before	Easy or hard to skip?

32. How many drinks did I have today?

33. Which ones could I cut out completely? Which feel very hard to let go of, and why?

34. Did I drink more alone or with others? Socially, after work, with food, at weekends, when stressed or tired?

35. What emotions sat underneath my drinking today? How did I feel while drinking, and afterwards?

Need more days? Print the diary pages again, or carry on in your notebook.